

Anger & Frustration

Knowledge base entry — general de-escalation and coping strategies for anger

Overview

Anger is a natural response to perceived unfairness, blocked goals, or feeling disrespected. It is not inherently negative — the goal is not to suppress it but to prevent it from driving impulsive decisions or damaging relationships, and to identify the underlying cause.

Common Triggers

- Feeling treated unfairly (grades, group project contributions, administrative issues)
- Blocked goals or repeated obstacles
- Miscommunication or conflict with friends, family, or peers
- Frustration with oneself (mistakes, missed deadlines)
- Accumulated stress where a small trigger causes a disproportionate reaction

De-escalation Strategies

- Pause before responding — a 90-second delay lets the initial physiological surge subside
- Physical release: brisk walk, or squeezing/releasing fists, to discharge adrenaline safely
- Name the underlying need: anger often masks hurt, fear, or feeling disrespected
- Avoid text/email/messages sent in the heat of the moment; draft and revisit later
- Use 'I' statements when addressing the issue: 'I felt frustrated when...' rather than blame-focused language

When to Encourage Professional Support

If anger frequently escalates to aggression, is difficult to control, or is damaging relationships or responsibilities repeatedly, a wellness assistant should suggest speaking with a counselor rather than relying solely on in-the-moment coping techniques.

Quick Reference Tips

- Cooling down physiologically (slow breathing, cold water on face/hands) precedes productive conversation
- Write down what specifically triggered the anger before it fades — useful for pattern-spotting later
- Anger that returns to the same trigger repeatedly usually points to an unresolved boundary issue
- Exercise is one of the most effective anger outlets backed by research